

VANTAGE

The Executive Presence Playbook

Gravitas, influence & the conversations that move careers

A 10-module framework distilled from the executive canon —
presence and persuasion through to negotiation and consultative selling.

Sample edition · grounded in 17 leadership, communication, negotiation and sales titles.

How to use this playbook

Executive presence is not a single trait — it is ten learnable capabilities, read in how you show up in real conversations. Each module below pairs the teaching with named, battle-tested methods from the literature, and a cue for what 'good' looks like on the tape. Learn the module, practise it in a real meeting, then let VANTAGE read your own conversation and tell you the one thing to change next.

Grounded in the canon

Executive Presence — Hewlett · Gravitas — Goyder · Crucial Conversations — Patterson et al. · Dare to Lead — Brown · Influence — Cialdini · How to Win Friends — Carnegie · Never Split the Difference — Voss · Say What You Mean — Sofer · Radical Candor — Scott · Gap Selling — Keenan · Little Red Book of Selling — Gitomer · Secrets of Closing the Sale — Ziglar · Negotiation Mastery · Leading Leaders — Salacuse · The Pyramid Principle — Minto

Module 1 — Executive Presence & Leadership Narrative

The composure, credibility, and story that make people see you as a leader.

Frameworks & methods

- The executive-presence triad (Hewlett)
- Gravitas through breath & voice (Goyder)
- The leadership narrative (Salacuse)
- Make the other person feel important (Carnegie)

Module 2 — Strategic & Concise Communication

Lead with the answer, structure top-down, and land the point at the right altitude.

Frameworks & methods

- The Pyramid Principle (Minto)
- Bottom Line Up Front / BLUF
- Signpost & the rule of three
- Altitude control

Module 3 — Influence, Audience Calibration & Stakeholder Management

Read the room and frame your message around what the audience actually values.

Frameworks & methods

- The six principles of influence (Cialdini)
- Talk in terms of their interests (Carnegie)
- Reading & leading the room (Goyder)
- Leading experts & stakeholders (Salacuse)

Module 4 — Mindful Presence, Confidence & Emotional Regulation

Catch your triggers at the choice-point and respond on purpose, not on impulse.

Frameworks & methods

- The choice-point (Crucial Conversations)
- Master my stories (Crucial Conversations)
- Grounded breath under pressure (Goyder)
- Grounded confidence (Brown)

Module 5 — Empathy, Listening & Trust Building

Hear what actually matters, ask the question that opens people up, and build trust.

Frameworks & methods

- Tactical empathy: labels & mirrors (Voss)
- Calibrated questions (Voss)
- Presence-based listening (Sofer)
- BRAVING trust (Brown)

Module 6 — Difficult Conversations, Feedback & Conflict Repair

Raise the hard thing, give real feedback, and stay in dialogue when it gets hot.

Frameworks & methods

- STATE the path (Crucial Conversations)
- Make it safe / start with heart
- Radical candor (Scott)
- Clear is kind (Brown)

Module 7 — Needs, Requests, Boundaries & Assertiveness

Own what you need, ask for it clearly, and set boundaries — directly and kindly.

Frameworks & methods

- Clear requests, not demands (Sofer)
- Observation vs evaluation (Sofer)
- Boundaries as clarity (Brown)
- Ask for what you want

Module 8 — Negotiation, Objection Handling & Value Protection

Work from interests, trade instead of conceding, and protect value to a clean close.

Frameworks & methods

- Interests, not positions — BATNA/ZOPA
- Trade, don't concede (Schatzki)
- No-oriented questions & accusation audit (Voss)
- Value protection & framing (Cialdini)

Module 9 — Sales & Consultative Conversation

Discover the real need before solutioning, and let the value sell itself.

Frameworks & methods

- Sell the gap (Keenan)
- Problem-first discovery (Schmitz)
- People buy for their reasons (Ziglar)
- Reduce the risk (Gitomer)

Module 10 — Self-Awareness, Habit Change & Deliberate Practice

Turn feedback into one focus at a time, practised in real life, until it sticks.

Frameworks & methods

- One focus at a time
- The learn → apply → re-measure loop
- Master my stories (self-awareness)
- Keystone habits

Put it to work

Reading changes what you notice; practice changes what you do. Pick the one module that matches your current challenge, run a real conversation through VANTAGE, and start the learn → apply → re-measure loop. We coach you — privately, on your own terms.